

Zoo Lions Act More Like Wild Lions With a Feast-and-Fast Menu

From: ScienceDaily Top Environment Mined: 2026-10-09 5 min read

Wild lions do not eat at the same time every day. Sometimes they have a big meal after a successful hunt, and then they go days without food. Scientists in Australia wanted to know what happens when zoo lions eat on a **schedule** that is more like that.

Researchers from Adelaide University worked with Monarto Safari Park in South Australia. They studied three adult male African lions. The lions were already on a feeding plan with times of eating and times of not eating. Then animal care staff added something new: every nine days, the lions got a whole animal to eat instead of just pieces of meat.

Eight **infrared** cameras recorded the lions day and night for three months. On whole-animal days, the lions spent almost three times as long eating as usual. They pulled, tore and worked at their food for long stretches, just as wild lions do.

After the big meal, the lions rested much longer. Then, as the days went by, they slowly became more active again. Scientists said this pattern of **feasting**, resting and then moving more closely matched what is seen in wild lions.

"Wild lions don't eat at the same time every day," said lead researcher Lesia Hryhorenko. She said whole meals give lions a chance to use natural **behaviors** that are an important part of their lives.

The team also watched **pacing**, when an animal walks back and forth. **Pacing** did not go up just because the lions were hungry. It rose most around **predictable** events, like when keepers arrived.

The study was published in the journal Applied Animal Behaviour Science.

Word Treasure

infrared -- A kind of light people cannot see, used by special cameras to film in the dark.

behaviors -- The ways an animal or person acts.

pacing -- Walking back and forth again and again in the same area.

predictable -- Able to be known ahead of time because it happens in a regular way.

schedule -- A plan that shows when things will happen.

feasting -- Eating a very large meal.

Background you need

In the wild, lions hunt, and because hunts do not always succeed, they may eat a lot at once and then go days without food.

Zoos and safari parks try to give animals chances to act naturally, which keepers call enrichment.

Scientists often use cameras to watch animals without disturbing them and to record what they do day and night.

Pacing, or walking back and forth, is a behavior keepers watch closely because it can show how an animal is feeling about its routine.

Break it down

LEAD: Zoo lions behave more like wild lions on a feast-and-fast schedule

KEY EVENT: Whole-animal meals added every nine days

+ - WHO: Adelaide University researchers and Monarto Safari Park

+ - WHAT: Three adult male African lions

+ - HOW: Eight infrared cameras filmed them for three months

FINDINGS: Almost three times longer eating, longer rest, then rising activity

EXTRA: Pacing rose most around predictable events, not hunger

SOURCE: Applied Animal Behaviour Science

Why it matters

Understanding how feeding routines affect animals can help zoos give lions lives that feel more natural and healthy.

Test what you remember

1. How often did the lions get a whole animal to eat?

- ☐ (A) Every three days
- ☐ (B) Every nine days
- ☐ (C) Every day
- ☐ (D) Once a month

2. How many lions were studied?

- ☐ (A) One
- ☐ (B) Twelve
- ☐ (C) Eight
- ☐ (D) Three

3. Where is Monarto Safari Park?

- ☐ (A) Kenya
- ☐ (B) South Australia
- ☐ (C) California
- ☐ (D) South Africa

4. How much longer did the lions spend eating on whole-animal days?

- ☐ (A) Almost three times as long
- ☐ (B) Twice as long
- ☐ (C) About the same
- ☐ (D) Ten times as long

5. What did the lions do right after the big meal?

- ☐ (A) Paced back and forth
- ☐ (B) Hunted again
- ☐ (C) Rested much longer
- ☐ (D) Played with keepers

6. When did pacing rise the most?

- ☐ (A) When the lions were hungriest
- ☐ (B) At night
- ☐ (C) On rainy days
- ☐ (D) Around predictable events like keeper arrivals

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: D 3: B 4: A 5: C 6: D

Questions to think about

1. Lead researcher Lesia Hryhorenko: Says wild lions do not eat at the same time every day and whole meals let lions use important natural behaviors.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):